Week 12: The Prophets

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

The prophets are some of the most misread books in the Bible — tonight we'll look at what they were actually for.

1. When you hear the word "prophet," what comes to mind first — a fortune-teller, a doomsday preacher, someone brave enough to say what nobody wants to hear? Where do you think that picture came from?

2. The prophets have been described as "covenant lawyers" — representing God's side of his relationship with Israel, accusing them when they break faith and calling them back when they stray. Does that change how you think about what a "prophetic voice" is supposed to do, then or now?

3. **Read Isaiah 1:10-20.** What does God say he wants instead of Israel's sacrifices, offerings, and festivals? What does it tell you that God cared more about "seeking justice" and "defending the oppressed" than about correct religious performance?

4. In that same passage, God says, "Though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow" — mercy offered in the very same breath as the accusation. What does it tell you about God's character that confrontation and forgiveness show up together like that?

5. **Read Hosea 13.** What images does God use to describe himself in this chapter, and what does he say Israel has forgotten? Why do you think God's anger might actually be evidence of love rather than the opposite of it?

6. Prophetic books tend to follow a pattern: accusation, a call to repent, and then an announcement of coming judgment and restoration — often in the very same poem. Why do you think the Bible holds judgment and hope together instead of separating "bad news" books from "good news" books?

7. **Read Isaiah 11:1-9.** What does the text say will characterize this coming king, and what happens between the animals later in the passage? What does this

picture of a coming king and a renewed creation tell you about what God is ultimately after?

8. The prophets were mostly ignored in their own lifetimes and only taken seriously after their warnings came true. Is there a "prophetic" voice in your own life right now — a person, a conviction, an uncomfortable truth — that you've been tuning out?

9. Where do you personally see the kind of thing the prophets railed against — injustice toward the vulnerable, worship or "faith" that's disconnected from how people actually treat each other? What would taking that seriously look like for you this week?